

Linux File Viewing Commands – Notes

1 cat Command

Definition

cat (concatenate) is used to **display file contents, combine multiple files, and create files.**

Syntax

```
cat filename
```

Common uses

```
cat file.txt
```

```
cat file1.txt file2.txt
```

```
cat > newfile.txt
```

Options

- -n → number all lines
- -b → number non-empty lines
- -E → show end of line as \$

Characteristics

- Displays **entire file at once**
- Not suitable for large files

Example

```
cat -n file.txt
```

2 more Command

Definition

more is a **pager command** used to view file contents **one screen at a time.**

Syntax

```
more filename
```

Navigation keys

- Space → next page
- Enter → next line
- q → quit

Characteristics

- Forward-only navigation
- Simple and lightweight
- Older command

Limitation



Cannot scroll backward

3 less Command

Definition

less is an **advanced pager** that allows **forward and backward navigation.**

Syntax

```
less filename
```

Navigation keys

- Space / PgDn → next page
- b / PgUp → previous page
- ↑ ↓ → scroll line by line
- /pattern → search forward
- ?pattern → search backward
- q → quit

Characteristics

- Faster for large files
- Powerful search
- Most commonly used pager

4 head Command

Definition

head displays the **first few lines** of a file.

Default behavior

- Shows **first 10 lines**

Syntax

```
head filename
```

Options

- -n N → display first N lines

Example

```
head -n 5 file.txt
```

Use cases

- Preview files
- Check headers or metadata

5 tail Command

Definition

tail displays the **last few lines** of a file.

Default behavior

- Shows **last 10 lines**

Syntax

```
tail filename
```

Options

- -n N → last N lines
- -f → follow file changes in real time

Examples

```
tail -n 20 file.txt
```

```
tail -f logfile.log
```

Use cases

- Monitor logs
- Debug running applications

6 Comparison Table

Command	Purpose	Navigation	Best Use
cat	Display full file	 None	Small files
more	Page-wise display	 Only down	Medium files
less	Advanced paging	  Both	Large files
head	First lines	 None	File preview
tail	Last lines	 None	Logs